Words and word-formation processes

We can very quickly understand a new word in our language (a **neologism**) and accept the use of different forms of that new word. This ability must derive in part from the fact that there is a lot of regularity in the word-formation processes in our language. In this chapter, we will explore some of the basic processes by which new words are created.

Etymology

The study of the origin and history of a word is known as its **etymology**,a term which,like many of our technical words, comes to us through Latin, but has its origins in Greek (*étymon* 'original form' + *logia* 'study of'), and is not to be confused with *entomology*, also from Greek (*éntomon* 'insect'). When we look closely at the etymologies of less technical words, we soon discover that there are many different ways in which new words can enter the language. We should keep in mind that these processes have been at work in the language for some time and a lot of words in daily use today were, at one time, considered barbaric misuses of the language. It is difficult now to understand the views expressed in the early nineteenth century over the 'tasteless innovation' of a word like *handbook*, or the horror expressed by a London newspaper in 1909 over the use of the newly coined word *aviation*. Yet many new words can cause similar outcries as they come into use today. Rather than act as if the language is being debased, we might prefer to view the constant evolution of new words and new uses of old words as a reassuring sign of vitality and creativeness in the way a language is shaped by the needs of its users. Let's consider the ways.

Coinage

One of the least common processes of word formation in English is coinage, that is, the invention of totally new terms. The most typical sources are invented trade names for commercial products that become general terms (usually without capital letters) for any version of that product.

New words based on the name of a person or a place are called *eponyms*

1. America. The word America is named after Italian Map maker, Amerigo Vespucci.
2. Caesar Salad. Restaurateur Caesar Cardini created the salad that now bears his name.
3. Boycott. This word is named for an Irish land agent, Captain Charles C.

Borrowing

As Bill Bryson observed in the quotation presented earlier, one of the most common sources of new words in English is the process simply labeled **bor- rowing**, that is, the taking over of words from other languages. . Throughout its history, the English language has adopted a vast

number of words from other languages, including *croissant* (French), *dope* (Dutch), *lilac* (Persian), *piano* (Italian), *pretzel* (German), *sofa* (Arabic), *tattoo* (Tahitian), *tycoon* (Japanese), *yogurt* (Turkish) and *zebra* (Bantu).

A special type of borrowing is described as **loan translation** or **calque**. In this process, there is a direct translation of the elements of a word into the borrowing language. Interesting examples are the French term *gratte-ciel*, which literally translates as 'scrape-sky', the Dutch *wolkenkrabber* ('cloud scratcher') or the German *Wolkenkratzer* ('cloud scraper'), all of which were calques for the English *skyscraper*.

Compounding

In some of those examples we have just considered, there is a joining of two separate words to produce a single form. Thus, *Lehn* and *Wort* are combined to produce *Lehnwort* in German. This combining process, technically known as **compounding**, is very common in languages such as German and English, but much less common in languages such as French and Spanish. Common English compounds are *bookcase*, *doorknob*, *fingerprint*, *sunburn*, *textbook*, *wallpaper*, *wastebasket* and *waterbed*.

Blending

The combination of two separate forms to produce a single new term is also present in the process called **blending**. . However, blending is typically accom- plished by taking only the beginning of one word and joining it to the end of the other word. . In some parts of the USA, there's a product that is used like *gasoline*, but is made from *alcohol*, so the 'blended' word for referring to this product is *gasohol*. To talk about the combined effects of *smoke* and *fog*, we can use the word *smog*. *brunch* (breakfast/lunch), *motel* (motor/hotel), *telecast* (television/broadcast).

Clipping

The element of reduction that is noticeable in blending is even more apparent in the process described as **clipping**. This occurs when a word of more than one syllable (*facsimile*) is reduced to a shorter form (*fax*), usually beginning in casual speech. The term *gasoline* is still used, but most people talk about *gas*, using the clipped form. Other common examples are *ad* (advertisement), *bra* (brassiere), *cab* (cabriolet), *condo* (condominium), *fan* (fanatic), *flu* (influenza), *perm* (per- manent wave), *phone*, *plane* and *pub* (public house). A particular type of reduction, favored in Australian and British English, produces forms technically known as **hypocorisms**. In this process, a longer word is reduced to a single syllable, then *-y* or *-ie* is added to the end. This is the process that results in *movie* ('moving pictures') and *telly* ('television'). It has also produced *Aussie* ('Australian'), *barbie* ('barbecue'), *bookie* ('bookmaker'), *brekky* ('breakfast') and *hankie* ('handkerchief'). You can probably guess what *Chrissy pressies* are.

Backformation

A very specialized type of reduction process is known as **backformation**. Typically, a word of one type (usually a noun) is reduced to form a word of another type (usually a verb). A good example of backformation is the process whereby the noun *television* first came into use and then the verb *televise* was created from it. Other examples of words created by this process are: *donate* (from 'donation'), *emote* (from 'emotion'), *enthuse* (from 'enthusiasm'), *liaise* (from 'liaison') and *babysit* (from 'babysitter'). Indeed, when we use the verb *backform* (*Did you know that 'opt' was backformed from 'option'?*), we are using a backformation.

Conversion

A change in the function of a word, as for example when a noun comes to be used as a verb (without any reduction), is generally known as **conversion**. . Other labels for this very common process are 'category change' and 'functional shift'. A number of nouns such as *bottle*, *butter*, *chair* and *vacation* have come to be used, through conversion, as verbs: *We bottled the home-brew last night*; *Have you buttered the toast?*; *Someone has to chair the meeting*; *They're vacationing in Florida*. These conversions are readily accepted, but some examples, such as the noun *impact* being used as a verb, seem to *impact* some people's sensibilities rather negatively.

Acronyms

Acronyms are new words formed from the initial letters of a set of other words. These can be forms such as *CD* ('compact disk') or *VCR* ('video cassette recorder') where the pronunciation consists of saying each separate letter. More typically, acronyms are pronounced as new single words, as in *NATO*, *NASA* or *UNESCO*. These examples have kept their capital letters, but many acronyms simply become everyday terms such as *laser* ('light amplification by stimulated emission of radiation'), *radar* ('radio detecting and ranging'), *scuba* ('self- contained underwater breathing apparatus') and *zip* ('zone improvement plan') code.

Derivation

In our list so far, we have not dealt with what is by far the most common word- formation process to be found in the production of new English words. This process is called **derivation** and it is accomplished by means of a large number of small 'bits' of the English language which are not usually given separate listings in dictionaries. These small 'bits' are generally described as **affixes**. Some familiar examples are the elements *un-*, *mis-*, *pre-*, *-ful*, *-less*, *-ish*, *-ism* and *-ness* which appear in words like *unhappy*, *misrepresent*, *prejudge*, *joyful*, *careless*, *boyish*, *terrorism* and *sadness*.

Prefixes and suffixes

Looking more closely at the preceding group of words, we can see that some affixes have to be added to the beginning of the word (e.g. *un-*). These are called **prefixes**. Other affixes have to be added to the end of the word (e.g. *-ish*) and are called **suffixes**. All English words formed by this derivational process have either prefixes or suffixes, or both. Thus, *mislead* has a prefix, *disrespectful* has both a prefix and a suffix, and *foolishness* has two suffixes.

Infixes

There is a third type of affix, not normally used in English, but found in some other languages. This is called an **infix** and, as the term suggests, it is an affix that is incorporated inside another word. For example, **cupful, spoonful, and passerby** can be pluralized as cupsful, spoonsful, and passersby, using "s" as an infix.

Multiple processes

Although we have concentrated on each of these word-formation processes in isolation, it is possible to trace the operation of more than one process at work in the creation of a particular word. For example, the term *deli* seems to have become a common American English expression via a process of first bor- rowing *delicatessen* (from German) and then clipping that borrowed form. If someone says that *problems with the project have snowballed*, the final word can be analyzed as an example of compounding in which *snow* and *ball* were combined to form the noun *snowball*, which was then turned into a verb through conversion. Forms that begin as acronyms can also go through other processes, as in the use of *lase* as a verb, the result of backformation from *laser*. In the expression *waspish attitudes*, the acronym *WASP* ('white Anglo-Saxon protes- tant') has lost its capital letters and gained a suffix (*-ish*) in the derivation process..An acronym that never seems to have had capital letters comes from 'young urban professional', plus the *-ie* suffix, as in hypocorism, to produce the word *yuppie* (first recorded in 1984). The formation of this new word, however, was helped by a quite different process, known simply as **analogy**, whereby new words are formed to be similar in some way to existing words. *Yuppie* was made possible as a new word by analogy with the earlier word *hippie* and another short- lived analogy *yippie*. The word *yippie* also had an acronym basis ('youth inter- national party') and was used for some students in the USA who were protesting against the war in Vietnam. One joke has it that *yippies* just grew up to be *yuppies*. And the process continues. Another analogy, with the word *yap* ('to make shrill noises'), helped label some of the noisy young professionals as *yappies*.

Many of these new words can, of course, have a very brief life-span. Perhaps the generally accepted test of the 'arrival' of recently formed words in a lan- guage is their published appearance in a dictionary. However, even this may not occur without protests from some conservative voices, as Noah Webster found when his first dictionary, published in 1806, was criticized for citing words like *advocate* and *test* as verbs, and for including such 'vulgar' words as *advisory* and *presidential*. It would seem that Noah had a keener sense than his critics of which new word forms in the language were going to last.